

The Therapist's Question gave you the technique in four stages: ask it, and ask it again on your own answer, until the chain stops moving. Lock it with a causal sentence. Test it against all three instances from your Surface Pattern work. Write the final wording.

Each of those four stages has its own way of quietly failing — a place where a session can feel finished while still sitting one level above the real thing. This document is organized the same way the technique is: one check per stage, so if a session comes up short, you know exactly where to look rather than re-reading four unrelated warning signs and guessing which one applies.

STAGE 1 · THE ITERATION

IT STILL SOUNDS LIKE SOMETHING THEY'D CHOOSE TO BELIEVE

When the downward chain stalls too early, the belief you're left holding usually has one of two tells. Either it's dressed as a virtue instead of a fear — something your character would say out loud, proudly, if you asked — or it's still something they could recognize and confirm about themselves without any resistance.

Neither of those is a hidden truth in the sense this course means it. The Hidden Truth established that a real core belief was never available to your character as a conscious claim — only as an assumption baked so deeply into how they experience the world that questioning it has never occurred to them. That changes what the real test should be. It isn't whether your character would *deny* the belief if you said it aloud — denial assumes they already have access to it and are defending against it, which puts you back in surface territory. The real test is whether they'd recognize it as a thought at all. A true hidden truth doesn't get denied. It gets missed entirely, and the character reaches for the justification again, because the justification is the only version of this that has ever existed in their conscious mind.

STALLED — STILL AT STAGE 1

"She believes in protecting the people she loves." Say this to Katniss directly and she'd nod — it's a value she'd claim for herself without hesitation. That ease of recognition is the tell. A belief your character would sign their name to isn't the one driving them from underneath.

CLEARED STAGE 1

"If I don't protect them, no one will — and they will be destroyed." Say this to Katniss and she wouldn't recognize it as something she thinks. She'd reach for the justification instead — *"I just do what has to be done"* — because this belief was never sitting in her conscious mind waiting to be confirmed. It was always underneath it.

Why this matters here: this check belongs at Stage 1 because it's the difference between stopping after one pass of the question and actually descending through it — catch it here, before you've built a lock on top of the wrong belief.

THE BEHAVIOR STILL FEELS LIKE A CHOICE

Your causal lock — “*Because I believe ___, I must ___*” — can be grammatically sound and still fail this check. The question isn't whether the sentence reads correctly. It's whether, once you've read it back, you can still picture your character weighing this decision and choosing differently.

A real hidden truth doesn't leave room for that image. If you can imagine your character pausing, considering the cost, and reasonably deciding not to act — the belief underneath hasn't earned the word *must* yet. It's still describing a strong preference, not a governing law.

STALLED — LOOSE LOCK

“Because I believe protecting people matters, I must protect them.” Read this back and it's easy to picture a version of Katniss who protects people *most* of the time — who might, under different pressure, decide the risk isn't worth it once. The belief permits an exception. That's the tell.

CLEARED STAGE 2

“Because I believe no one will protect the people I love if I don't, I must position myself between them and whatever threatens them — every time, regardless of the cost to me.” There's no version of this character who sits this one out. The belief doesn't permit an exception, which is exactly what makes the lock hold.

Why this matters here: this is the moment you're most likely to accept a belief because the sentence sounds finished, not because the behavior is actually inevitable given it. A lock that admits an exception is a preference wearing a causal sentence.

THE BELIEF ONLY EXPLAINS SOME OF THE EVIDENCE

Run your locked belief against all three instances from your Surface Pattern PDF, one at a time, not just the instance you had in mind while you were building the lock. Watch for the moment the belief needs a little help — an extra clause, a special circumstance — to cover one of them.

STALLED — STRAINS ON ONE INSTANCE

The belief covers Katniss volunteering at the Reaping and shielding Rue cleanly — both strangers or family, both immediate physical threats. But keeping Peeta alive takes more explaining: he's an ally who could be read as competition, not someone she's protecting on sight. If your reasoning needs a bridge like *“well, in this case, she also...”* to make the third instance fit, the belief isn't finished.

CLEARED STAGE 3

“If I don't protect them, no one will — and they will be destroyed” covers all three without a bridge: her sister, Rue, and Peeta are each, in the moment, someone who will be destroyed unless Katniss specifically intervenes. No instance needs a special case built onto the belief to make sense.

Why this matters here: this is the check that proves you've found the character's belief, not just a belief that explains one good scene. A belief that needs help on the third instance will need help again in your manuscript, on a scene this exercise never tested.

THE STATEMENT IS TOO CLEAN TO BE TRUE

A belief can clear every check above and still go wrong in the last step: how you write it down. The most common failure here isn't a wrong belief — it's a right belief flattened into a diagnosis. Somewhere between discovering the hidden truth and writing the final sentence, it's easy to compress a specific, character-shaped fear into a general psychological label. The label sounds insightful. It's also no longer usable, because it no longer belongs to anyone in particular.

The test is simple: could this sentence, unchanged, be pasted onto a different character in a different book? If yes, it's a category, not a hidden truth. A real one names a specific object of fear, a specific stake, and reads as something only this person, in this story, would believe.

STALLED — A LABEL, NOT A BELIEF

"Katniss has a fear of loss and a need for control." This is accurate, generic, and could be written about a dozen protagonists in a dozen different genres without changing a word. It describes a category of person. It does not explain why *this* person does *this specific thing*.

CLEARED STAGE 4

"If I don't protect them, no one will — and they will be destroyed." This could not be lifted onto another character without becoming false. It names who needs protecting, why the responsibility falls specifically to her, and what's actually at stake if she's wrong. It reads like something drawn out of one particular life, not assigned from outside it.

Why this matters here: this is the last checkpoint before the deliverable is locked in for good. A belief that was genuinely excavated can still be lost in translation on the way to the final sentence — this catches that before it becomes what you carry into your revision.

- 1 Unrecognized, not denied. Your character wouldn't confirm this belief if you named it — they'd reach for the justification instead.
- 2 No exceptions. The causal lock doesn't leave room for a version of your character who reasonably chooses otherwise.
- 3 Covers all three. The belief explains every documented instance without a bridge or special case.
- 4 Couldn't be borrowed. The final sentence would sound false pasted onto any other character.

NONE OF THESE MEAN THE SESSION WENT WRONG

Hitting one of these four is not a sign your character lacks depth, or that you've done the work badly. It's the ordinary shape of excavation — you almost always pass through the justification, the loose lock, and the partial fit on your way to the real thing. Catching yourself at one of these stages means the method is working exactly as intended. Correct it in the moment, in whichever stage you're in, and keep going.

*The coach should be asking the questions.
You should be the one who notices when an answer is still too easy.*

STAY IN THE STAGE YOU'RE IN. DON'T MOVE ON UNTIL IT CLEARS.

NEXT — LESSON 3

Your character believes this now. Believed it long enough, deeply enough, that it shapes every significant relationship in their life. Lesson 3 doesn't ask where this belief came from in the abstract — it asks what specifically happened that convinced them it was true. That's the formative wound, and it's the next rung on this ladder.

FURTHER READING

Burns, D. D. (1980). *Feeling Good: The New Mood Therapy*. William Morrow.

Beck, J. S. (2020). *Cognitive Behavior Therapy: Basics and Beyond* (3rd ed.). Guilford Press.

Beck, A. T. (1967). *Depression: Clinical, Experimental, and Theoretical Aspects*. Hoeber.